RAG Learning

2.5 Power & Borders (OCR Component 2)

This topic examines the nature of political power, how it is exercised at different scales (local to global), and the significance of borders in shaping geopolitical relationships. It covers sovereignty, superpowers and emerging powers, theories of power (hard, soft, smart), contested borders, global governance institutions, and the shift from a unipolar to a multipolar world order. Understanding power dynamics is essential for making sense of almost every other topic in geography.

1. Sovereignty and the Nation-State

Sovereignty: The supreme authority of a state to govern itself and make decisions within its territorial boundaries without external interference. Sovereignty has two dimensions: internal sovereignty (effective control over domestic affairs — law enforcement, taxation, legislation) and external sovereignty (recognition by other states as a legitimate independent entity, entitling membership of international organisations). In practice, sovereignty exists on a spectrum — no state has absolute sovereignty in an interconnected world.

Nation-state: A political unit in which the boundaries of the state (defined territory governed by a single political authority) coincide with those of the nation (a group of people sharing common identity, culture, language, history, and often ethnicity). True nation-states are rare — most states contain multiple national, ethnic, or linguistic groups (multinational states), and many nations lack their own state (stateless nations).

Key Concepts

Term	Definition	Examples
State	A defined territory with a permanent population, an effective government, and the	France, Nigeria, Brazil, Japan

	capacity to enter into relations with other states (Montevideo Convention, 1933). There are 193 UN member states	
Nation	A group of people who share a common identity based on ethnicity, language, culture, religion, or history — a community of shared belonging. A nation may or may not have its own state	Kurds (no state), Basques, Catalans, Scots, the Jewish nation (before and after Israel)
Nation-state	A state where the majority of citizens share a common national identity and the state's boundaries closely correspond to the nation's extent	Japan (98.5% ethnically Japanese), Iceland, Poland (closely aligned); very few pure examples exist
Multinational state	A state containing multiple distinct national, ethnic, or cultural groups	UK (English, Scottish, Welsh, Northern Irish), India (2,000+ ethnic groups, 22 official languages), Russia (190+ ethnic groups), Nigeria (250+ ethnic groups)
Stateless nation	A national group that identifies as a distinct people but lacks its own sovereign state	Kurds (~30–40 million across Turkey, Iraq, Syria, Iran — the world's largest stateless nation), Palestinians, Tibetans, Rohingya, Uyghurs, Roma
Failed/fragile state	A state that has lost the ability to provide basic governance, security, and essential services to its population. Characterised by loss of monopoly on violence, breakdown of rule of law, and inability to collect taxes or deliver public goods	Somalia (no effective central government 1991–2012), South Sudan, Yemen, Libya, Syria, Central African Republic. The Fragile States Index (Fund for Peace) ranks 179 countries annually

Challenges to Sovereignty in the 21st Century

The Westphalian model of absolute state sovereignty (established 1648) faces unprecedented challenges:

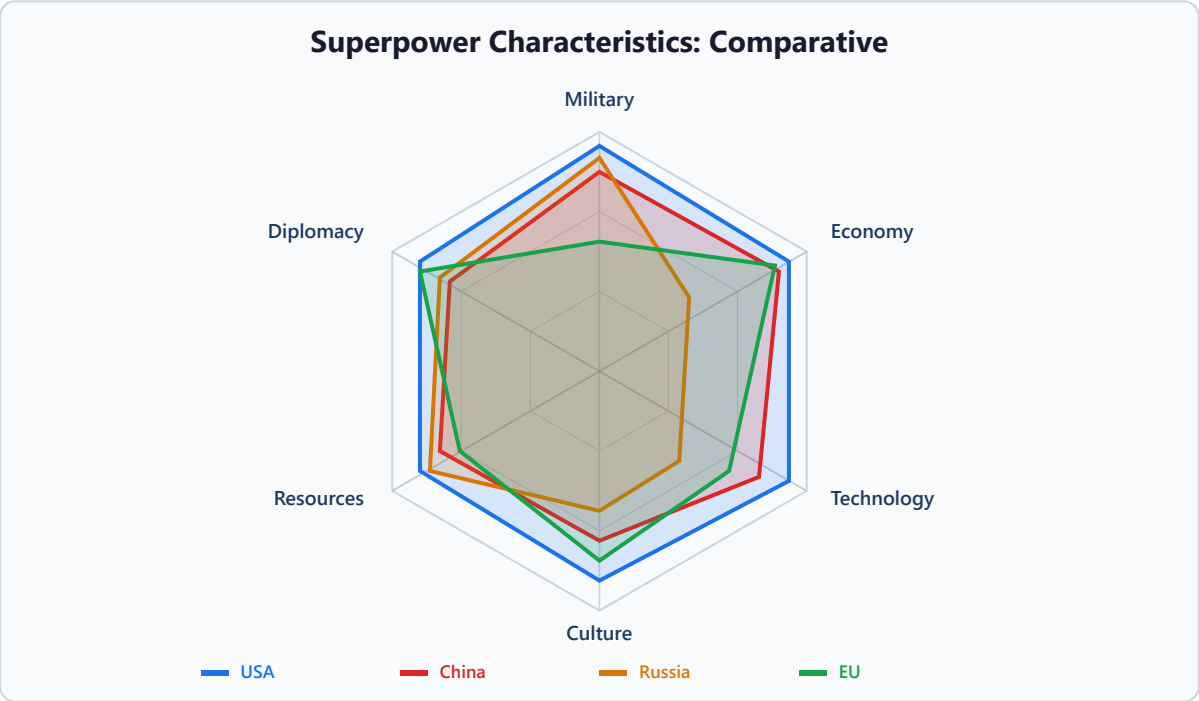
- **Globalisation:** TNCs operate across borders with revenues exceeding the GDP of many states (Apple's revenue > GDP of Portugal). Global financial markets can destabilise national economies (2008 crisis). Supply chains link every country to external dependencies. States cannot unilaterally control capital flows, information, or environmental pollution
- **Supranational organisations:** EU law takes precedence over domestic law in member states. WTO rules constrain trade policy. UN Security Council resolutions are binding on all member states. IMF conditionality dictates economic policy in borrowing countries. These institutions pool sovereignty — individual states gain collective influence but lose unilateral control
- **International law and norms:** The ICC prosecutes individuals for genocide and war crimes regardless of state sovereignty. The R2P doctrine (Responsibility to Protect, 2005) explicitly states that sovereignty is conditional on a state protecting its population from mass atrocities. Universal human rights standards challenge the idea that states can treat citizens however they wish
- **Technology and cyberspace:** The internet, social media, and encrypted communications enable non-state actors to organise, communicate, and challenge state control of information. Cyber warfare (Russian interference in US elections 2016; state-sponsored hacking) blurs the boundaries of territorial sovereignty. Surveillance capitalism (Big Tech) accumulates power that rivals or exceeds state capacity
- **Separatist and independence movements:** Catalonia (2017 independence referendum — declared illegal by Spain), Scotland (2014 referendum: 45% Yes; demand for second referendum post-Brexit), Quebec, Kurdistan, Kashmir, Tibet — internal demands for self-determination challenge territorial integrity
- **Climate change:** A transboundary threat that no single state can address alone. Requires collective governance that inherently limits individual state autonomy. Small island states may lose their entire territory to sea-level rise, creating unprecedented questions about sovereignty without territory

Exam Tip: Brexit is an excellent case study for discussing sovereignty. The Leave campaign's central argument was reclaiming sovereignty from the EU ("Take Back Control"). But critics argue that in an interconnected world, formal sovereignty does not necessarily equate to greater real-world power or influence — the UK outside the EU has less influence over European regulations that still affect its trade, and must negotiate individually with major blocs where it previously had collective bargaining power. Use Brexit to discuss the tension between sovereignty and interdependence.

2. Superpowers

Superpower: A state with dominant influence in global affairs, possessing overwhelming military, economic, political, and cultural power that extends far beyond its borders. During the Cold War (1947–1991), the USA and USSR were the two superpowers (bipolar world order). Since 1991, the USA has been the sole superpower (unipolar moment), though China is increasingly regarded as a peer competitor.

Emerging power: A state whose rapid economic growth, large population, and increasing global influence suggest it could become a superpower or great power. Often characterised by industrial transformation, growing diplomatic assertiveness, and expanding military capabilities. The BRICS grouping (Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa — expanded in 2024 to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, UAE) represents the main emerging power bloc.



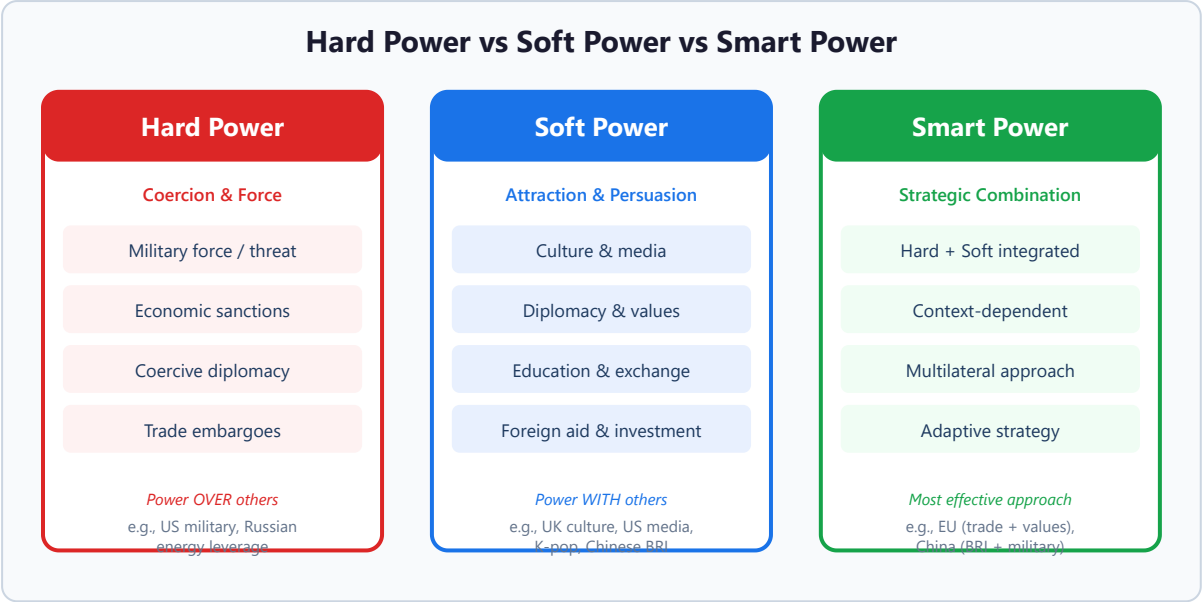
Superpower Profiles

Characteristic	USA	China	Russia	EU (collective)
Military	Largest military budget ($886bn, 2024 — 39% of	2nd largest budget (~$230bn official, likely higher); rapidly	5,977 nuclear warheads (world's largest arsenal); significant	Combined forces significant (1.4 million active personnel) but no unified command or

	global total); 750+ overseas bases in 80 countries; 11 aircraft carriers; 5,500+ nuclear warheads; NATO leader; global force projection capability	modernising navy (largest in world by ship count); expanding nuclear arsenal (~350 warheads); no formal military alliances; A2/AD strategy in Western Pacific	conventional forces but poorly performing in Ukraine; major arms exporter; limited overseas bases (Syria, various African states)	foreign policy; depends on NATO/USA for collective defence; France and UK have nuclear weapons; EU battle groups rarely deployed
Economy	Largest GDP ($27tn+); dominant in finance, tech, pharma, services; US dollar as global reserve currency (~60% of reserves); home to 7 of world's 10 largest companies by market cap	2nd largest GDP ($18tn nominal; 1st by PPP); world's manufacturing hub (28% of global output); BRI investment in 140+ countries; world's largest trading nation; growing consumer market (400 million middle class)	11th largest GDP (~$2tn); heavily dependent on hydrocarbon exports (oil and gas = 40% of government revenue); sanctions since 2022 have restricted access to Western technology and finance; war economy strains	2nd largest economy collectively (~$18tn); largest trading bloc by value; euro is 2nd most-used currency; single market of 450 million consumers; major aid donor (EU institutions + members = ~50% of global ODA)
Cultural (soft power)	Dominant global culture: Hollywood, streaming platforms (Netflix, Disney+), social media (Meta, X, YouTube),	Growing: 500+ Confucius Institutes promoting Chinese language; TikTok (1.5bn users); film industry expanding; but limited by	Limited and declining: RT media network reaches millions but credibility damaged post-Ukraine invasion; classical cultural exports (ballet, literature,	Significant: European fashion, cuisine, film, tourism, education, sport (UEFA Champions League, FIFA World Cup often hosted); shared democratic/human rights values; European languages (French,

	music, English language, universities (8 of world's top 10), fast food brands, fashion, sports (NBA, NFL)	language barriers, censorship, and authoritarian image. "Wolf warrior diplomacy" has damaged soft power	music); Russian Orthodox Church influence in Eastern Europe/Balkans	Spanish, German) widely spoken globally
Diplomatic	UN Security Council P5 (veto); extensive alliance network (NATO, AUKUS, Quad, bilateral treaties with Japan, South Korea, Philippines); can be unilateralist (Iraq 2003) or isolationist (Trump era)	P5 member; BRI creates diplomatic leverage via debt and infrastructure; Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; increasing influence in UN system (heads 4 of 15 specialised agencies); South-South diplomacy	P5 member (veto used frequently to block action on Syria, Ukraine); key player in Middle East and Central Asia; limited remaining allies (Belarus, North Korea, Iran, Syria); declining soft power but nuclear status ensures relevance	Major multilateral actor; 27 member states coordinate foreign policy; largest collective aid donor; strong climate diplomacy (Paris Agreement leadership); but slow decision-making and internal divisions limit coherence (e.g., Hungary blocking Ukraine support)

3. Theories of Power



Joseph Nye's Concept of Soft Power (1990)

Political scientist Joseph Nye coined the term "soft power" to describe the ability to shape the preferences and behaviour of others through attraction and persuasion rather than coercion or payment. Soft power rests on three pillars:

1. **Culture:** When a nation's culture includes universally attractive values, ideas, and creative outputs that others want to emulate (e.g., Hollywood, K-pop, British universities, French cuisine, Italian fashion, Japanese anime)
2. **Political values:** When a nation lives up to its stated values both domestically and in foreign policy (democracy, human rights, rule of law, transparency). Hypocrisy erodes soft power (e.g., US advocacy for democracy undermined by Guantanamo Bay, Abu Ghraib, and domestic racial inequality)
3. **Foreign policy:** When policies are perceived as legitimate, multilateral, and morally authoritative (development aid, climate leadership, peacekeeping). Unilateral military action (Iraq 2003) severely damaged US soft power

The **Soft Power 30 Index** (Portland Communications) consistently ranks the UK, France, Germany, and USA among the top soft power countries, with the UK often first — due to the BBC, Premier League, universities, English language, cultural exports, and diplomatic network.

Case Study: China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) — Smart Power in Action

Launched by President Xi Jinping in 2013, the BRI is China's signature geopolitical project, combining economic investment (soft power) with strategic positioning (hard power implications):

- **Scale:** 140+ countries signed BRI memoranda of understanding. Over $1 trillion invested globally by 2024 in ports, railways, roads, power plants, digital infrastructure, and special economic zones. Key projects: China-Pakistan Economic Corridor ($62 billion); Piraeus port, Greece (majority Chinese-owned); Mombasa-Nairobi railway, Kenya; new capital city construction in Egypt
- **Supporters' view:** BRI fills critical infrastructure gaps in developing countries that Western institutions (World Bank, IMF) have been too slow or conditional to address. It creates connectivity, reduces trade costs, and stimulates economic growth in recipient countries. China offers loans without the political conditionality (democracy, human rights reforms) that Western lenders demand
- **Critics' view:** "Debt-trap diplomacy" — countries that cannot repay Chinese loans are pressured to cede strategic assets. Sri Lanka leased its Hambantota Port to China for 99 years after defaulting on $1.4 billion in Chinese loans. Zambia reportedly offered its national electricity utility as collateral. Environmental damage (coal power plants in Pakistan, deforestation for railways). Labour rights abuses (Chinese companies import Chinese workers rather than employing locals). Extension of Chinese surveillance infrastructure (Huawei 5G networks, facial recognition systems)
- **Geopolitical significance:** BRI creates a network of economic dependencies that give China diplomatic leverage. Countries receiving Chinese investment are less likely to support Taiwan, criticise China's human rights record, or vote against China at the UN. The Digital Silk Road extends this to cyberspace, with Chinese technology standards potentially becoming dominant in developing world
- **Western response:** EU's Global Gateway ($340 billion), USA's Partnership for Global Infrastructure and Investment ($600 billion pledged at G7, 2022), and the UK's BII (British International Investment) are explicitly designed to offer alternatives to BRI. But: commitments have been slow to materialise compared to China's rapid disbursement

Geopolitical Theories

Theory	Key Thinker	Core Idea	Contemporary Relevance
Heartland Theory	Halford Mackinder (1904)	Whoever controls the Eurasian "Heartland" (roughly Central Asia/Siberia) controls the "World-	Explains Russian strategic anxiety about NATO encirclement and its focus on controlling buffer states (Ukraine, Belarus, Central Asia).

		Island" (Eurasia + Africa) and thereby the world. Land power is supreme.	China's BRI extends infrastructure into the Heartland. Underpins arguments for why control of Central Asia remains strategically vital
Rimland Theory	Nicholas Spykman (1944)	The coastal "Rimland" of Eurasia (Western Europe, Middle East, South and East Asia) is more strategically important than the Heartland. Control the Rimland, and you contain the Heartland power.	Directly influenced US Cold War strategy of "containment" through bases and alliances along the Eurasian periphery (NATO in Europe, bilateral alliances in Asia). Explains US military presence in Japan, South Korea, the Gulf, and Europe today
World Systems Theory	Immanuel Wallerstein (1974)	The world is divided into core (dominant, wealthy), semi-periphery (intermediate), and periphery (dependent, exploited) nations. Power and wealth flow from periphery to core through unequal exchange. The system is structurally unequal and self-reinforcing.	Explains persistent global inequality; unequal trade relationships; why LICs remain dependent on primary exports while HICs dominate high-value services and manufacturing. Links to dependency theory and neo-colonialism arguments
Clash of Civilisations	Samuel Huntington (1993)	Post-Cold War conflicts will be along cultural/civilisational fault lines (Western, Islamic, Confucian, Hindu, etc.) rather than ideological (capitalist vs communist) or purely economic.	Debated in context of "War on Terror", rise of political Islam, China-West tensions, and cultural identity politics. Widely criticised as essentialist, reductive, and dangerously self-fulfilling. Ignores diversity within civilisations and cross-cultural cooperation

4. Contested Borders

Contested border: A boundary between states (or within a state) that is disputed, with competing claims to sovereignty over territory, resources, or strategic position. Contested borders can lead to armed conflict, diplomatic crises, displacement of populations, and chronic instability. There are approximately 150 active territorial disputes worldwide.

Major Contested Borders & Territories

Kashmir
India vs Pakistan (vs China)
Since 1947; nuclear-armed states; Line of Control
Status: Active dispute

South China Sea
China vs Philippines, Vietnam, Malaysia, Brunei, Taiwan
Artificial islands; $3.4tn trade
Status: Escalating tensions

Israel-Palestine
Competing sovereignty claims
West Bank, Gaza, Jerusalem
Since 1948; 700,000+ settlers
Status: Active conflict

Crimea / Ukraine
Russia annexed 2014;
Full-scale invasion 2022
NATO/EU vs Russia proxy
Status: Active war

Korean DMZ
North vs South Korea
Since 1953 armistice
Nuclear threat; 28,500 US troops
Status: Frozen conflict

Arctic Region
Russia, Canada, USA, Norway, Denmark
Resources + shipping routes
Status: Growing competition

Common Causes of Border Disputes

Resources	Identity	Historical	Strategic	Political
Oil, gas, water, fish	Ethnic, religious, national	Colonial legacy, treaties	Military, trade routes	Ideology, nationalism

Case Study: South China Sea — Resource Competition and Great Power Rivalry

China claims approximately 90% of the South China Sea through its "nine-dash line," overlapping with claims from the Philippines, Vietnam, Malaysia, Brunei, and Taiwan:

- **Strategic importance:** $3.4 trillion in trade passes through annually (~30% of global maritime trade). Contains estimated 11 billion barrels of oil and 190 trillion cubic feet of natural gas. Rich fishing grounds provide food and livelihoods for millions
- **China's actions:** Since 2013, China has constructed 7 artificial islands on submerged reefs in the Spratly Islands, building military installations including 3 airstrips (3,000+ m, capable of handling military jets), radar systems, missile batteries, hangars, and barracks. Dredging has destroyed coral reef ecosystems. China has also deployed coast guard and fishing militia vessels to intimidate Filipino and Vietnamese fishermen
- **International law:** In 2016, the Permanent Court of Arbitration (The Hague) ruled that China's nine-dash line claim had no legal basis under UNCLOS (UN Convention on the Law of the Sea) and that China had violated Filipino sovereign rights. China rejected the ruling, calling it "null and void" — a direct challenge to the rules-based international order

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- **USA response:** The US Navy conducts "freedom of navigation" operations (FONOPS), sailing warships through waters China claims as territorial. The USA has strengthened alliances with the Philippines, Japan, and Australia (AUKUS nuclear submarine deal). Risk of miscalculation leading to military confrontation is considered one of the highest geopolitical risks globally
- **Significance:** The dispute illustrates how competing resource demands, national identity and historical claims, great power rivalry, and the limitations of international law can turn maritime borders into potential flashpoints for conflict

Case Study: Russia-Ukraine Conflict (2014–present)

The most significant challenge to European border stability since 1945:

- **Background:** Ukraine gained independence in 1991 after the USSR's dissolution. Russia views Ukraine as within its sphere of influence and considers NATO expansion to its borders an existential threat. Ukraine's 2014 Euromaidan revolution (toppling the pro-Russian president) triggered the crisis
- **Crimea (2014):** Russia annexed Crimea following a disputed referendum, the first forcible change of European borders since 1945. Crimea has strategic value: the Russian Black Sea Fleet is based at Sevastopol; the peninsula has ~2 million people, a majority of whom identify as ethnically Russian
- **Full-scale invasion (February 2022):** Russia launched a multi-axis invasion of Ukraine with 190,000 troops. Initial objective of rapid regime change in Kyiv failed. The war has become a prolonged conflict of attrition
- **Humanitarian impact:** Tens of thousands of military and civilian casualties on both sides; 6.3 million Ukrainian refugees fled abroad (largest European refugee crisis since WWII); 5.9 million internally displaced; cities devastated (Mariupol, Bakhmut, Kherson); allegations of war crimes (Bucha massacre, targeting of civilian infrastructure)
- **Global consequences:** Global food crisis (Ukraine and Russia together produce 30% of world wheat exports; Black Sea grain corridor disrupted); energy crisis in Europe (Russia cut gas supplies, forcing emergency diversification; European gas prices rose 10x); unprecedented Western sanctions on Russia (asset freezes, SWIFT disconnection, trade restrictions); NATO reinvigorated (Finland and Sweden joined; defence spending increased across the alliance); nuclear escalation risk

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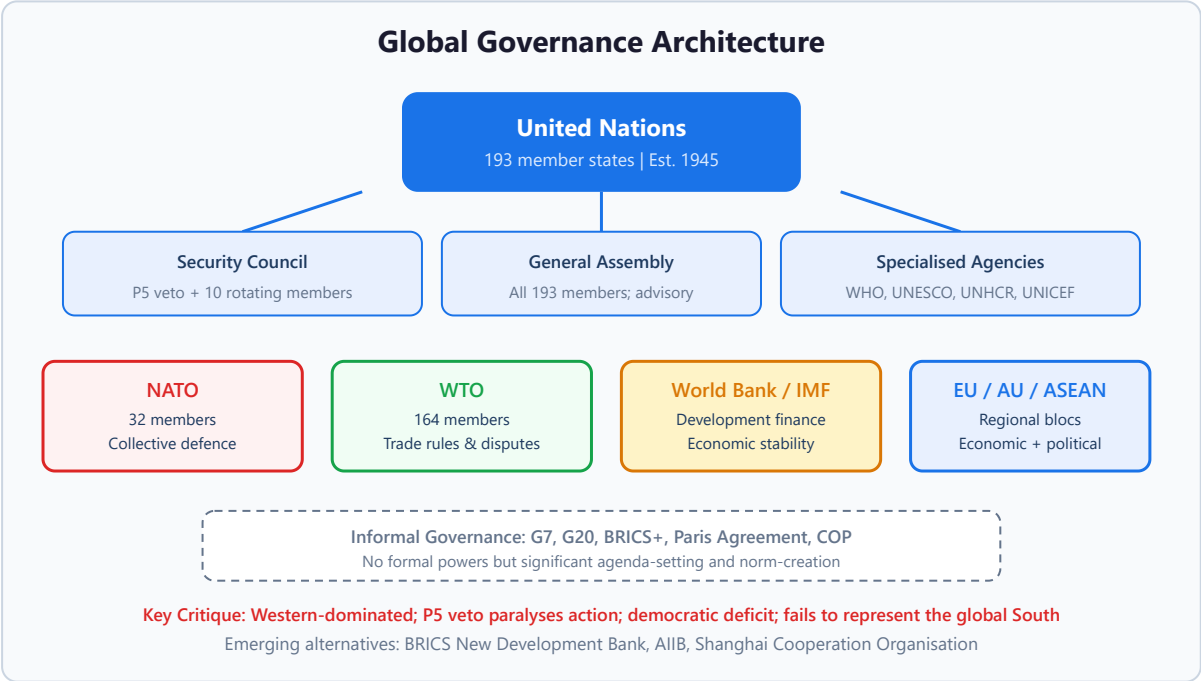
- **Significance:** Demonstrates the limitations of international law and organisations when a nuclear-armed permanent Security Council member commits aggression. Challenges the post-1945 norm that borders cannot be changed by force. Has accelerated the shift towards a multipolar world and deepened the divide between the Western-aligned and Russia/China-aligned blocs

5. Global Governance

Global governance: The collective management of common problems at the international level through institutions, rules, norms, and processes. It includes formal organisations (UN, WTO, NATO, ICC, World Bank, IMF) and informal arrangements (G7, G20, BRICS, climate agreements, Davos/World Economic Forum). Global governance is not world government — it is voluntary, often non-binding, and depends on the consent and cooperation of sovereign states.



Evaluating the United Nations

Strengths	Limitations

Universal membership (193 states) gives unmatched legitimacy and moral authority	Security Council P5 veto paralyses action on major crises (Russia vetoed 16 resolutions on Syria; China and Russia blocked action on Myanmar)
Specialised agencies deliver vital services: WHO coordinated global COVID response; UNHCR protects 100+ million displaced people; UNICEF vaccinates 45% of world's children	Chronically underfunded: total UN system budget (~$56 billion) is less than the New York City budget. The USA and other major contributors sometimes withhold funding as political leverage
Platform for negotiation and multilateral agreements (Paris Climate Agreement, SDGs, nuclear non-proliferation)	Slow bureaucracy; Security Council composition reflects 1945 power distribution (no permanent seats for India, Japan, Germany, Brazil, or any African country)
Peacekeeping has prevented escalation in some conflicts (87,000 personnel in 12 operations)	Peacekeeping failures (Rwanda 1994, Srebrenica 1995, South Sudan) and scandals (sexual exploitation by peacekeepers in DRC, Haiti) undermine credibility
Normative influence: human rights treaties, SDGs, R2P, and other frameworks set global standards	No enforcement mechanism: states can ignore UN resolutions, recommendations, and court rulings with limited consequences

6. Changing Global Power Dynamics

The Shift from Unipolarity to Multipolarity

The post-Cold War unipolar moment (1991–~2008, characterised by unchallenged US dominance) is giving way to a more complex, multipolar world order characterised by multiple centres of power and influence:

- **China's rise:** Second-largest economy; world's largest trading nation; BRI creating global infrastructure network; military modernisation (largest navy by number of vessels); assertive policy on South China Sea, Taiwan Strait, and Hong Kong. The USA-China relationship is the defining geopolitical axis of the 21st century
- **BRICS expansion:** Originally Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa (2010). Expanded in 2024 to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, and UAE. BRICS+ represents ~46% of world population, ~37% of global GDP (PPP), and ~44% of world oil production. Challenges Western-dominated institutions by creating alternative financial infrastructure (BRICS New Development Bank, Contingent

Reserve Arrangement). However: internal cohesion is limited — India and China have border disputes; Saudi Arabia and Iran are historic rivals

- **Relative US decline:** US share of global GDP has fallen from ~31% (2000) to ~25% (2023). Withdrawal from Afghanistan (2021) damaged credibility. Political polarisation and governance dysfunction (government shutdowns, debt ceiling crises) raise questions about reliability. "America First" rhetoric under Trump signalled potential retreat from multilateral commitments
- **Regional powers with independent agency:** Turkey, Saudi Arabia, India, Indonesia, and Nigeria increasingly pursue autonomous foreign policies rather than aligning with either the USA or China. India, for example, buys Russian oil while participating in the US-led Quad alliance — "multi-alignment" rather than alignment
- **Non-state actors:** TNCs (Apple, Amazon, Alphabet have revenues exceeding the GDP of most countries), terrorist organisations (ISIS controlled territory larger than the UK in 2015), NGOs, social media platforms (Meta, TikTok can shape elections and revolutions), and criminal networks increasingly influence global affairs beyond state control

Case Study: The Rise of China

China's transformation is arguably the most significant geopolitical shift since the end of the Cold War:

- **Economic transformation:** GDP grew from ~$150 billion (1978) to $18+ trillion (2023). 800 million lifted out of extreme poverty (largest poverty reduction in human history). China overtook Japan as world's 2nd largest economy in 2010 and became the world's largest economy by PPP in 2014. It is the world's largest manufacturer, exporter, and holder of foreign exchange reserves ($3.2 trillion)
- **From factory to innovator:** China has moved up the value chain from cheap manufacturing to high-tech production. It dominates global solar panel (80%+), battery (75%+), and electric vehicle production. Huawei, BYD, DJI, TikTok, and SHEIN are globally competitive brands. China files more patents than any other country and graduates 5 million STEM students annually
- **Military modernisation:** Defence budget ~$230 billion (official; real figure likely higher). World's largest navy by vessel count. Hypersonic missiles, anti-satellite weapons, stealth fighters. Military facilities on artificial islands in the South China Sea. Increasing assertiveness around Taiwan (frequent military exercises simulating invasion)
- **Domestic challenges:** Ageing population (working-age population peaked in 2015; fertility rate 1.0 — among world's lowest); property market crisis (Evergrande, Country Garden defaults); youth

unemployment ~20% in 2023; growing debt ($50+ trillion); environmental degradation; growing authoritarianism under Xi Jinping (removal of term limits, crackdown on dissent, Uyghur persecution in Xinjiang)

- **Strategic rivalry with the USA:** Trade war (tariffs from 2018); technology competition (US CHIPS Act restricts semiconductor exports to China; TikTok bans debated); Taiwan tensions (the USA maintains "strategic ambiguity" about whether it would defend Taiwan militarily); competing influence in the Global South. Some analysts describe the relationship as a "new Cold War," though economic interdependence makes the analogy imperfect

7. Borders, Migration, and Identity

The Significance of Borders

Borders are not merely lines on a map — they are political, economic, social, and cultural constructs that profoundly shape human experience, opportunity, and identity:

- **Physical barriers:** Walls and fences proliferating globally: US-Mexico border wall ($15+ billion); Israel's West Bank separation barrier (708 km, declared illegal by the ICJ in 2004); Hungary's border fence (175 km, built in 2015 to block refugees); India-Bangladesh border fence (3,200 km, the world's longest). There are now 74 border walls globally, up from 15 in 1990
- **Economic boundaries:** Tariffs, customs procedures, trade agreements, and regulatory standards create economic borders that determine what flows freely (capital within trade blocs) and what is restricted (labour, goods from non-members). Brexit created a new economic border within the island of Ireland, requiring the complex Northern Ireland Protocol
- **Digital borders:** Internet censorship, data sovereignty laws, and surveillance technologies create new forms of territorial control in cyberspace. China's Great Firewall blocks access to Google, Facebook, Twitter, Wikipedia, and thousands of other sites for 1.4 billion people. Russia's "sovereign internet" law enables the state to disconnect from the global internet. The EU's GDPR creates a regulatory border for data
- **Cultural and linguistic boundaries:** Language, religion, and ethnicity create invisible borders that may or may not align with political ones. The Durand Line (Afghanistan-Pakistan border) splits the Pashtun people; the Kurdish population spans four states; the Sahel marks a transition zone between Arab/Muslim North Africa and Sub-Saharan/Christian/animist Africa

Colonial Legacy and Borders

Many of today's contested borders were drawn by colonial powers with little regard for existing ethnic, linguistic, religious, or cultural boundaries. The Berlin Conference (1884–85) divided Africa among European powers using straight lines on maps, creating states that grouped hostile communities together and split unified peoples across borders. This legacy continues to fuel conflict:

Case Study: The Sykes-Picot Agreement (1916) and the Middle East

The secret agreement between Britain (Sir Mark Sykes) and France (Francois Georges-Picot) divided the Ottoman Empire's Middle Eastern territories into spheres of influence, creating the borders of modern Iraq, Syria, Lebanon, and Jordan:

- **What they did:** Drew straight-line borders through diverse populations with no consultation of local peoples. France received Syria and Lebanon; Britain received Iraq, Jordan, and Palestine. The borders grouped together Sunni Arabs, Shia Arabs, Kurds, Christians, Druze, Alawites, Turkmen, and other communities with conflicting identities and interests
- **Consequences that persist today:** The Kurdish question — 30–40 million Kurds split across Turkey, Iraq, Syria, and Iran, denied their own state despite being the world's largest stateless nation. Sectarian conflict in Iraq (Sunni vs Shia vs Kurdish) that contributed to the rise of ISIS. The Israel-Palestine conflict (Britain's Balfour Declaration 1917 promised a Jewish homeland in Palestine without consulting Arab inhabitants). Lebanon's sectarian power-sharing system (mandated by France) has produced chronic political dysfunction and civil war (1975–1990)
- **Symbolic importance:** When ISIS declared its "caliphate" in 2014, it explicitly stated it was erasing the Sykes-Picot border between Iraq and Syria. The enduring resentment of colonial border-drawing demonstrates how borders imposed from outside can lack legitimacy for generations
- **Broader lesson:** Borders that do not reflect the identities and interests of the people living within them are inherently unstable. Colonial borders are a root cause of conflict, displacement, and governance challenges across Africa and the Middle East

Exam Tip: When discussing power and borders, always think synoptically and link to other topics: globalisation (is the world becoming more or less borderless? Evidence points both ways — free trade agreements reduce economic borders while physical walls proliferate), migration (how do borders affect human movement, and how does migration challenge borders?), sovereignty (how do

supranational institutions challenge state borders?), inequality (how do borders create and maintain unequal access to resources, rights, and opportunities? The "birth lottery" — where you are born determines your life chances more than almost any other factor), and human rights (borders restrict freedom of movement while potentially protecting national identity and security). The strongest answers weave multiple themes together with well-chosen evidence. Use the question stem to decide which connections are most relevant.